

SETI Post-Detection Hub

2025 SETI PC Committee annual update:
a brief summary of our activities

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It has been **an excellent year for the Hub**, growing tangible research to share with the wider SETI community, and community-building efforts, that help catalyse and support ongoing work.

The first ***Post-Detection Futures Workshop*** meeting took place at St Andrews in July 2025. With the aim of thinking creatively, expansively, and rigorously about candidate conditions for life, the workshop combined animal studies, engineering, and philosophy with futures research, modelling, and speculative fiction to address the ‘unknown unknowns’ of post-discovery.

The workshop explored the philosophical and ethical challenges of defining life, technology, and intelligence in the context of SETI, including the difficulty of distinguishing natural from artificial signals.

Post-Detection Futures took a proactive approach to developing and demonstrating speculative methods and tools. These tools, grounded in the real ambiguities of astronomical data, proceed from the assumption that a signal may not be clean, obvious, or even intelligible. By integrating non-human communication, cognitive science, health and humanities, the workshop reframed detection not as an endpoint, but as the beginning of a proactive scientific and societal endeavour.

- Outreach - Media, Filming (documentary / podcasts, etc), and Social Media.
- British (OBO Royal Society) & Irish Science festivals – The Hub was invited to and participated in both events, presenting our work to the public.
- Many new projects started / starting, inc. software development – updated analytical tools; AI Tools being developed, to enhance our capabilities.
- Scenario modelling & Toolkit – phase 1 now completed and available: *see final slide*.
- UK Government – Space Directorate – very positive ongoing dialogue for future engagement
- House of Lords (UK) – Submission of Written Evidence to the House of Lords Select Committee on UK Engagement with Space.
- NASA DARES white paper: *SETI Post-Detection: “Transforming Future Research for Unprecedented Technosignature Discoveries”* – excellent media and community feedback.

- PSETI – significant contribution to 2025 symposium, leading breakout sessions, plus papers and posters.
- New Hub members – Hub community continues to grow and strengthen.
- Funding initiatives – St Andrews initiatives in pipeline, with planned events and ongoing discussions.
- Survey – new survey designed and now soon to be launched – this also builds on our 2019 Royal Society “From Afar” survey. Student (Hub led / supervised) projects (including OOTC) are ongoing with some completions achieved, this year.
- Student (Hub led / supervised) projects (including, Order of the Crow) are ongoing with some completions achieved, this year.
- Hub Newsletter – The Waterhole, is now a regular monthly publication (Carol Oliver, Editor).

The Post-Detection Toolkit – an example output

This is an evolving resource for the SETI community; its archive forms a distinct, open commons that grows through the ongoing addition and accumulation of detection scenarios.

We invite contributions to expand the current sample of detection scenarios: you may invent your own scenarios, or “translate” moments from science fiction (out-of-copyright) and notable false alarms in SETI history into structured entries for the list. Shared entries will be added to the Hub wiki for collective review and collaboration.

Scan for more info & resources:

